Forms

In short

Online forms should work for everyone, including people who use screen readers or only a keyboard. Give every field a proper label, and don’t rely on placeholder text. Error messages should say what’s wrong and how to fix it.

What is it for?

An accessible form is an online form that everyone can fill in, including people with vision, movement, or cognitive disabilities. It collects information, such as contact details, sign-ups, feedback, or payments. It does this in a way that is clear and easy for everyone to use, including people who use screen readers or only a keyboard.

Inaccessible forms create significant barriers that can prevent people from completing essential tasks. These barriers include:

- Missing or unlinked labels: Screen reader users don't know what information to enter in a form field
- Poor keyboard navigation: Users who cannot use a mouse are unable to 'Tab' to form fields, buttons, or links in a logical order, or they get trapped in one section
- Vague error messages: Errors that only use a red border (relying on colour alone) or say "Invalid input" don't tell a user what is wrong or how to fix it
- Small tap targets: Small radio buttons or checkboxes are difficult to select for users with motor impairments
- Overly complex layouts or time limits can create cognitive barriers, making the form confusing or stressful to complete

All modern web browsers and assistive technologies (like screen readers) fully support the standard HTML elements and Accessible Rich Internet Applications (ARIA) attributes needed to create accessible forms. These HTML elements include <label>, <input>, <fieldset>, and <legend>.

How to support it

To ensure your form is accessible, you should build it with semantic HTML and clear instructions from the start.

- Always use `<label>` tags and associate them with their inputs (using the `for` and `id` attributes)
    - Placeholder text (for example, "Enter your name") is not a substitute for a label
- Group related fields
    - Use a `<fieldset>` to group related items, such as the radio buttons for a "Yes" or "No" question, or the fields for a delivery address. Use a `<legend>` to describe the group
- Provide clear error validation
    - When a form has errors after the user submits it, the message should be in text, identify the specific field, clearly describe the problem, and suggest a correction
- Ensure full keyboard accessibility
    - A user must be able to navigate to every form field, link, and button in a logical sequence, using only the keyboard. For example, they might use 'Tab', 'Shift + Tab', the arrow keys, and 'Space'.
- Use high-contrast colours for text, borders, and controls, and ensure all clickable elements have a large enough target size.

Useful links

- World Wide Web Consortium (W3C) WAI: Forms Tutorial
- WebAIM: Creating Accessible Forms
- MDN: Web Forms

Abbreviations

The full form of each abbreviation used in this document.

ARIA: Accessible Rich Internet Applications

HTML: HyperText Markup Language

MDN: Mozilla Developer Network

W3C: World Wide Web Consortium

WAI: Web Accessibility Initiative